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CAMBRIDGE IGCSE • FIRST LANGUAGE ENGLISH • 0500

Language Analysis Workbook

Step-by-step practice for the Paper 1 Question 3 language task (200–250 words, 10 marks): six original extracts, a guided method and model answers for every one.

- ◆ 6 original extracts
- ◆ Choose → Zoom → Connect tables
- ◆ 6 model answers
- ◆ Effect phrase bank
- ◆ 3 guided, 3 independent
- ◆ Worked example for each
- ◆ Six mistakes that cost marks
- ◆ Marking bands & tracker

Marcé van Moerkerken

PGCE Secondary English (Summa Cum Laude)
International school English teacher, UAE

For exams in 2027, 2028 and 2029. Independent practice material; not produced or endorsed by Cambridge University Press & Assessment. All extracts are original.

How to use this workbook

In Paper 1 Question 3, students analyse how a writer uses language in two named paragraphs of Text C, in about 200–250 words, for 10 marks. The skill improves quickly with focused, repeated practice. This workbook provides it.

The method: Choose → Zoom → Connect

Choose	Pick three or four short, powerful choices from each paragraph: single words and short phrases work best.
Zoom	Explain the literal meaning, then the connotations: the feelings and images the words carry.
Connect	Explain the effect on the reader: what picture or mood is created, and why the writer wants it.

The route through the book

Extracts 1–3	Guided. Fill in the Choose → Zoom → Connect table (a worked example is given), then write it up.
Extracts 4–6	Independent. Plan quickly, then write 200–250 words in about 25 minutes, as in the exam.
After each one	Compare with the model answer. Highlight one explanation in the model that is better than yours, and rewrite one of your own sentences in the same way.

Phrases for explaining effect

- “...suggests that...”
- “...carries connotations of...”
- “...implies...”
- “...personifies... as...”
- “...so the reader feels...”
- “...emphasising how...”
- “...creating a sense of...”
- “...contrasts with..., highlighting...”

Six mistakes that cost marks

Mistake	Weak	Strong
Feature-spotting	The writer uses personification and a simile.	"The clock... ticked with maddening slowness, each second dragging its feet" personifies time as reluctant, making the wait feel cruel.
"Vivid imagery"	This creates vivid imagery and makes the reader want to read on.	"Ash drifted down like dirty snow" twists something beautiful into something polluted, showing how the fire spoils everything.
Quoting too much	"The storm came in from the sea at dusk, dragging a curtain of black cloud across the harbour."	"dragging" suggests the cloud is hauled over the city like a heavy curtain.
Retelling the story	The family packs quickly and drives away while the fire gets closer.	The rapid verbs "snatched", "flung" and "clutched" convey desperation rather than careful packing.
Ignoring one paragraph	Five choices from paragraph 1, one from paragraph 2.	Three or four choices from each paragraph named in the question.
No overall effect	Ending on a single word choice.	"Overall, the writer creates a sense of energy and release as the storm breaks the city's stifling calm."

THE GOLDEN RULE: Every choice needs three things: the **words** (short quotation), the **meaning or connotation**, and the **effect** on the reader. The marks come from the explanation.

Rain Over the City

- 1 The storm came in from the sea at dusk, dragging a curtain of black cloud across the harbour. The first drops were fat and heavy, smacking into the dust like thrown coins. Then the sky split open. Rain hammered the rooftops, drummed on car bonnets and turned the gutters into brown, gurgling rivers that swallowed litter and leaves in a single gulp.
- 2 The city, which had been sweltering and sluggish all afternoon, jolted awake. Shopkeepers scrambled to drag their displays inside. Pedestrians scattered like startled pigeons, newspapers held uselessly over their heads. Only the children were delighted: they leapt from puddle to puddle, shrieking, faces tilted to the sky as if the rain were a gift that had been promised to them for months.

Task [10 marks]: Re-read the extract. Explain how the writer uses language to convey **the arrival of the storm** in paragraph 1 and **the city's reaction to the rain** in paragraph 2. Select three or four powerful words or phrases from each paragraph. Write about **200 to 250 words**.

Step 1: Choose → Zoom → Connect

	Choice (1–4 words)	Literal meaning	Connotations	Effect on the reader
Example	“dragging”	pulling with effort	heavy, slow, forceful; a curtain being closed	darkness is forced over the city – ominous, like the end of a performance
Paragraph 1				
Paragraph 1				
Paragraph 1				
Paragraph 2				
Paragraph 2				
Paragraph 2				

Step 2: Turn your table into two paragraphs, one per paragraph of the extract, and finish with one sentence on the overall effect.